Chapter 31

Going beyond Herself: Multitasking

CRIME PREVENTION WAS ALWAYS TOP PRIORITY FOR KIRAN WHEREVER she was posted. Her track record is replete with measures taken to prevent potentially negative and harmful situations from developing. Her approach has all along been to anticipate events and guide their course towards a positive goal. Her energies have been channelized towards *proactive prevention* rather than after-the-event reaction. Her first community project in crime prevention became visible during her posting in 1980 as deputy commissioner Delhi (west) where she used her powers, in a benign way, to persuade an erstwhile criminal tribe of bootleggers in Delhi to abandon their ways of earning a livelihood by brewing and selling illicit liquor and take up acceptable, non-criminal ways of making a living. She succeeded in her mission. (For details see Chapter 8.)

Six years later, in her next district police charge, on seeing a strong nexus between drug dependence and crime, she went about setting up six drug abuse treatment centres in six police station premises, which was something absolutely unheard of. In a situation in which a police officer did not want to handle a single drug addict, lest something happen to the latter, Kiran went about housing over a hundred drug dependents for residential care and treatment in police stations within her area of responsibility. Mere words just cannot describe the courage and the conviction behind this endeavour.

Her work became a pioneering movement compelling not only the community but also the government to sit up and take notice. She travelled around the country giving slide presentations, explaining the consequences of drug dependence and highlighting the lessons to be learnt by schools, universities, parents, police and the community at large. As she was about to be transferred in 1988, people of her district insisted that she institutionalize the good work. She then set up a foundation called ‘Navjyoti’ meaning ‘new light’.

The then police commissioner, Ved Marwah, also Kiran’s mentor, blessed the new foundation. Since then, Navjyoti has provided residential treatment to nearly 20,000 drug and alcohol dependents and has benefited thousands more through its community outreach programmes in India. The Navjyoti Foundation has since been institutionalized into the Drug Demand Reduction, Training and Research Centre. Aid came in from diverse sources. The Japanese Embassy offered to bear the building costs; the Gujarat-based K. K. Shah Charitable Trust paid for the land; and the Yamuna Pushta Trust (which obtained finances from the Netherlands) contributed towards an additional hall, which was allocated for training purposes. This centre, with sustained support from the Government of India, provides holistic treatment based on homoeopathy, naturopathy, yoga, meditation and therapeutic counselling of the patient and his or her immediate family. Besides treatment, the centre has received support from a German NGO and also from the American Government to enable it move into the area of research and training as well. In every programme of Nayjyoti, community strength has continued to grow through